

# SMB Cloud Storage: Vendor Perceptions and Concept Test

## QUESTIONNAIRE REQUIREMENT DOCUMENT (QRE)

| Field       | Detail                                                               |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Client      | Helix Data Systems                                                   |
| Job number  | HDS-2026-041                                                         |
| Version     | v2.0 FINAL, 22 June 2026                                             |
| Author      | S. Iyer, Senior Research Executive                                   |
| Method      | Online, B2B panel plus client list sample                            |
| Market      | United States and United Kingdom                                     |
| Target LOI  | 18 minutes                                                           |
| Sample size | n = 400 completes, 250 US and 150 UK                                 |
| Complexity  | Moderate. Piping, rotated grids, concept exposure, nested conditions |

## Notes for the programmer

1. Disable the back button from Q7 onwards. Concept exposure must not be revisited.
2. Enable save and resume. A respondent returning after a break re-enters at the last completed question.
3. Randomise where instructed. Store the display order of every randomised list as a separate variable in the export.
4. Anchored items never rotate. Exclusive items clear all other selections when chosen.
5. Capture time on page for Q7 separately from overall LOI.
6. Sample source is passed in the URL as src=panel or src=list. Store as a hidden variable.
7. Quota cells are checked at S2 and again at the point of complete. If a cell fills between those two points, allow the respondent to finish and flag as over-quota rather than terminating mid-survey.

## Quotas

| Quota group  | Cell                  | US target | UK target | Behaviour when full |
|--------------|-----------------------|-----------|-----------|---------------------|
| Company size | 10 to 49 employees    | 100       | 60        | Terminate, code 30  |
| Company size | 50 to 249 employees   | 100       | 60        | Terminate, code 30  |
| Company size | 250 to 999 employees  | 50        | 30        | Terminate, code 30  |
| Role         | IT decision maker     | 150       | 90        | Soft, monitor only  |
| Role         | Finance or operations | 100       | 60        | Soft, monitor only  |

## Section A. Screener

### ASK ALL

S1. Which of the following best describes your role at your organisation?

*Single code. Do not randomise.*

- |                                                      |   |                    |
|------------------------------------------------------|---|--------------------|
| IT or technology decision maker.....                 | 1 |                    |
| Finance leadership.....                              | 2 |                    |
| Operations leadership.....                           | 3 |                    |
| Individual contributor, no purchase involvement..... | 4 | TERMINATE, CODE 10 |
| Student, retired or not currently employed.....      | 5 | TERMINATE, CODE 10 |
| Other.....                                           | 6 | TERMINATE, CODE 10 |

### ASK ALL

S2. Approximately how many people does your organisation employ worldwide?

*Single code. Apply the company size quota at this question.*

|                    |   |                    |
|--------------------|---|--------------------|
| Fewer than 10..... | 1 | TERMINATE, CODE 11 |
| 10 to 49.....      | 2 |                    |
| 50 to 249.....     | 3 |                    |
| 250 to 999.....    | 4 |                    |
| 1,000 or more..... | 5 | TERMINATE, CODE 11 |

#### ASK ALL

**S3.** How involved are you in decisions about cloud storage and data infrastructure for your organisation?

*Single code.*

|                                          |   |                    |
|------------------------------------------|---|--------------------|
| I am the final decision maker.....       | 1 |                    |
| I am one of several decision makers..... | 2 |                    |
| I recommend but do not decide.....       | 3 |                    |
| I am consulted occasionally.....         | 4 | TERMINATE, CODE 12 |
| I am not involved.....                   | 5 | TERMINATE, CODE 12 |

## Section B. Current vendor landscape

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#### ASK ALL WHO QUALIFY

**Q1.** Which of the following cloud storage providers does your organisation currently use in any capacity?

*Multi code. RANDOMISE codes 1 to 8. Anchor code 9 and code 10 last, in that order. Code 10 is exclusive.*

|                                               |    |                    |
|-----------------------------------------------|----|--------------------|
| Amazon S3.....                                | 1  |                    |
| Microsoft Azure Blob Storage.....             | 2  |                    |
| Google Cloud Storage.....                     | 3  |                    |
| Backblaze B2.....                             | 4  |                    |
| Wasabi.....                                   | 5  |                    |
| Dropbox Business.....                         | 6  |                    |
| Box.....                                      | 7  |                    |
| Helix Vault.....                              | 8  |                    |
| Another provider.....                         | 9  |                    |
| We do not use any cloud storage provider..... | 10 | TERMINATE, CODE 13 |

*Store the count of selections at Q1 as a hidden variable QCOUNT for use at Q4.*

#### ASK IF MORE THAN ONE PROVIDER SELECTED AT Q1 (QCOUNT > 1)

**Q2.** And which one of these would you describe as your primary provider?

*Single code. PIPE IN only the providers selected at Q1, keeping the Q1 display order.*

*IF ONLY ONE PROVIDER WAS SELECTED AT Q1, AUTO-PUNCH IT AS PRIMARY AND SKIP THIS QUESTION.*

#### ASK ALL

**Q3.** For approximately how many years has your organisation used [PIPE: PRIMARY PROVIDER FROM Q2]?

*Numeric entry, one decimal allowed. Valid range 0.1 to 25. If the entry exceeds 25, show a soft check: You have entered a value above 25 years, please confirm.*

#### ASK ALL

**Q4.** Approximately what is your organisation's total annual spend on cloud storage, in your local currency?

*Numeric entry. Show the currency symbol based on country. Valid range 500 to 5,000,000. Add a Don't know checkbox, code 98, which clears the numeric field when ticked.*

## Section C. Vendor performance

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#### ASK ALL

**Q5.** How would you rate each of the providers you use on the following dimensions?

*Grid. ROWS are the providers selected at Q1, capped at the first four in display order. ROTATE row order independently of the Q1 order. COLUMNS are the dimensions below, ROTATE column order. Scale is 1 to 7 where 1 is Very poor and 7 is Excellent. Add a Cannot rate option coded 98 at the end of every scale, do not rotate it.*

| Dimension                        | Variable |
|----------------------------------|----------|
| Reliability and uptime           | Q5a      |
| Value for money                  | Q5b      |
| Ease of integration              | Q5c      |
| Quality of technical support     | Q5d      |
| Security and compliance features | Q5e      |
| Transparency of pricing          | Q5f      |

## Section D. Concept exposure

### ASK ALL

**Q6.** On the next screen you will see a description of a new service. Please read it carefully. You will not be able to return to it afterwards.

*Display only, no response captured. Continue button appears after 3 seconds.*

### ASK ALL

**Q7.** [CONCEPT A: DISPLAY THE STIMULUS IMAGE SUPPLIED SEPARATELY AS HDS\_CONCEPT\_A.PNG]

*Display only. Continue button hidden for the first 15 seconds. Record time on page as a separate variable T\_Q7. Disable the back button from this point forward.*

### ASK ALL

**Q8.** Based on what you have just read, how likely would your organisation be to consider this service?

*Single code, 5-point scale, do not randomise.*

- Definitely would consider.....5
- Probably would consider.....4
- Might or might not consider.....3
- Probably would not consider.....2
- Definitely would not consider.....1

### ASK IF Q8 = 4 OR 5

**Q9.** What is it about this service that appeals to you most?

*Open text, minimum 10 characters.*

### ASK IF Q8 = 1 OR 2

**Q10.** What is it about this service that puts you off?

*Open text, minimum 10 characters.*

### ASK IF Q8 = 3

**Q11.** What would need to change for your organisation to consider this service?

*Open text, minimum 10 characters.*

## Section E. Feature priorities

### ASK ALL

**Q12.** Of the features listed below, which five are most important to your organisation when choosing a cloud storage provider? Please rank your top five, where 1 is the most important.

*Ranking question, exactly five ranks required. RANDOMISE codes 1 to 11. Anchor code 12 last, and if code 12 is ranked, show a text box for specification.*

- Per-gigabyte storage cost.....1
- No charge for data retrieval.....2
- Guaranteed uptime in the contract.....3
- Data residency in our own country.....4
- Certified compliance, for example ISO 27001.....5
- Native integration with our existing tools.....6
- Speed of restore after an outage.....7

|                                               |    |
|-----------------------------------------------|----|
| Named technical account manager.....          | 8  |
| Ability to move data out without penalty..... | 9  |
| Automatic tiering of cold data.....           | 10 |
| Published carbon footprint reporting.....     | 11 |
| Something else.....                           | 12 |

## Section F. Switching intent

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### ASK ALL

**Q13.** How likely is your organisation to change its primary cloud storage provider in the next 12 months?

*Single code, 1 to 5 where 5 is Very likely.*

### ASK IF Q13 = 1 OR 2

**Q14.** What are the main reasons your organisation is unlikely to switch?

*Multi code, maximum three selections. RANDOMISE codes 1 to 7. Anchor code 8 last, exclusive.*

|                                                     |   |
|-----------------------------------------------------|---|
| Migration would be too disruptive.....              | 1 |
| We are locked into a contract.....                  | 2 |
| Our team knows the current platform well.....       | 3 |
| The cost of moving data out is prohibitive.....     | 4 |
| We are satisfied with current performance.....      | 5 |
| No clear alternative is better.....                 | 6 |
| We lack the internal resource to manage a move..... | 7 |
| Some other reason.....                              | 8 |

### ASK IF Q13 = 4 OR 5

**Q15.** What is prompting your organisation to consider a change?

*Multi code, maximum three selections. RANDOMISE codes 1 to 6. Anchor code 7 last, exclusive.*

|                                                 |   |
|-------------------------------------------------|---|
| Cost has risen.....                             | 1 |
| Reliability or outage problems.....             | 2 |
| Poor support experience.....                    | 3 |
| A compliance or data residency requirement..... | 4 |
| A better offer from another provider.....       | 5 |
| A wider change to our technology stack.....     | 6 |
| Some other reason.....                          | 7 |

### ASK IF Q13 = 4 OR 5 AND Q3 IS LESS THAN 2

**Q16.** You mentioned your organisation has used its current provider for a relatively short time. What has fallen short of expectations?

*Open text. Note the compound condition, this question is asked only where both criteria hold.*

## Section G. Firmographics

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### ASK ALL

**D1.** In which country are you based?

*Single code. Pre-populate from the sample file where available and confirm rather than ask.*

|                     |   |
|---------------------|---|
| United States.....  | 1 |
| United Kingdom..... | 2 |
| Somewhere else..... | 3 |

**TERMINATE, CODE 14**

### ASK ALL

**D2.** Which of these best describes your organisation's primary industry?

*Single code, dropdown. Standard industry list SIC-12 supplied separately.*

## Appendix A. Termination and disposition codes

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| Code | Reason                                  | Disposition       |
|------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------|
| 10   | Role not qualified at S1                | Screen-out        |
| 11   | Company size out of scope at S2         | Screen-out        |
| 12   | Insufficient purchase involvement at S3 | Screen-out        |
| 13   | No cloud storage used at Q1             | Screen-out        |
| 14   | Country out of scope at D1              | Screen-out        |
| 30   | Company size quota full                 | Quota full        |
| 50   | Over-quota complete, retained           | Complete, flagged |
| 99   | Complete                                | Complete          |

## Appendix B. Export requirements

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The data file must contain, in addition to the answer variables:

- The randomised display order for Q1, Q5 rows, Q5 columns, Q12, Q14 and Q15, each as a separate order variable.
- T\_Q7, the time in seconds spent on the concept screen.
- QCOUNT, the number of providers selected at Q1.
- The piped primary provider from Q2 as both a code and a text label.
- src, the sample source passed in the URL.
- Overall LOI in seconds, and the terminate code for every incomplete.